In Russia and the Ukraine, borscht often includes tomatoes as well as beets. This version may seem unusual, but you will love its rich color and fantastic taste.

tomato borscht

SERVES 4 **PREP** 25 MINS **COOK** 25 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

2 tbsp olive oil
1 small onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, chopped
8oz (225g) raw beets, peeled and finely grated
1 tsp freshly ground toasted cumin seeds
¼ tsp ground cinnamon
8oz (225g) ripe fresh tomatoes, peeled and coarsely chopped
1 cup tomato juice
1 tbsp sun-dried tomatoes, very finely chopped
2½ cups vegetable stock
1 tbsp soy sauce
salt and freshly ground black pepper
toasted cumin seeds, to serve
sour cream or crème fraîche, to serve

1 Heat the oil in a heavy pan over low heat. Gently cook the onion and garlic for about 5 minutes, then add the beets. Cook gently for another 10 minutes, stirring from time to time, until softened but not browned.

2 Add the ground spices, tomatoes, tomato juice, and sun-dried tomatoes, then pour in the stock. Bring to a boil. Reduce the heat slightly, cover, and simmer very gently for 15 minutes or until all the vegetables are soft. Remove from the heat. Blend or process until velvety smooth.

3 Check the seasoning, adding the soy sauce, salt, and pepper to taste. Serve chilled, at room temperature, or slightly warm. If you do reheat the soup, do so gently over low heat. To serve, spoon into bowls, and garnish with toasted cumin seeds and a spoonful of sour cream or crème fraîche.